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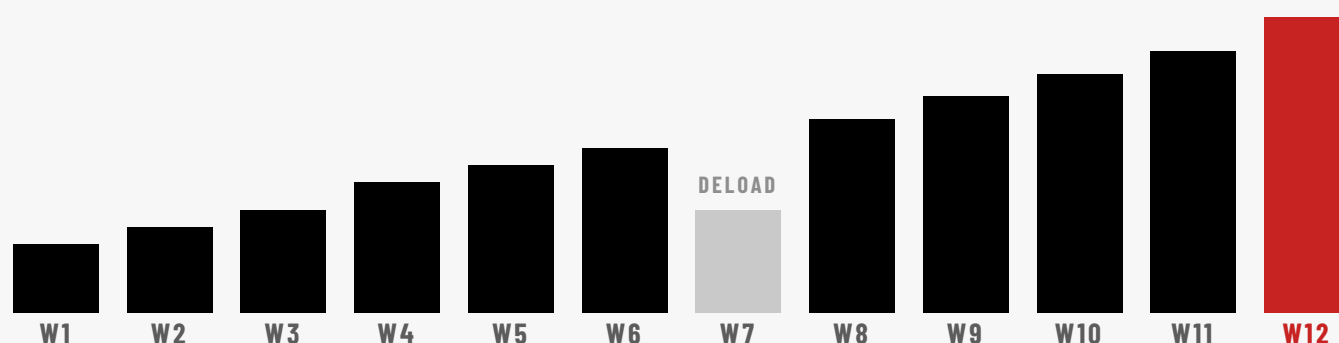
ISSUE 02 – 2026
FREE WORKBOOK

• FREE WORKBOOK – ISSUE 02

The 12-Week *Progressive Overload* Workbook



Exactly what to add, and when, every week for 12 weeks. Plus the log pages to track every set.



p.06

THE DOUBLE PROGRESSION RULE

The one method a beginner needs

p.04

THE NEW RULES OF 2026

ACSM's first update in 17 years

p.11

COACH INTERVIEW

"Small wins, every week"

p.15

PRINTABLE TRAINING LOGS

Track every set, every week

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ACSM guidelines in plain English

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FROM THE COACH

Now what?

Issue 01 gave you a starting point: the right reps, the right sets and a simple three-day plan. This issue answers the question that comes next. *What do I do now?*

The answer is progressive overload: doing a little more over time. Most people know the phrase. Far fewer have a plan for it, so they lift the same weights for months and wonder why nothing changes.

This workbook is that plan. Twelve weeks, three sessions a week, and one clear rule that tells you when to add weight. Every page is built to be used, not only read. Fill in the logs, tick off the weeks, and look back at week 1 when you reach week 12.

Print the log pages. Bring them to the gym. Write everything down.

**Sadia Baloch**Certified Fitness Coach,
ExerciseMenu.com**7+**

YEARS COACHING

257+

CLIENTS

95%

SATISFACTION

1. READPages 3–8
once, before
week 1.**2. TRAIN**Follow pages
9–10 three
times a week.**3. LOG**Fill in pages
15–16 after
every
session.

FEATURE

Why your workouts *stop working*

Why progress stalls after a few good months, and the principle that gets it moving again.

Your first month of training feels like magic. The weights climb, your clothes fit differently and every session brings something new. Then, somewhere around week six or eight, it stalls. Same weights. Same reps. Same reflection in the mirror.

Nothing is wrong with you. Your body did what it was built to do: it adapted to the demand you gave it. Muscles grow and get stronger because training creates a stress they are not yet prepared for. Once they handle that stress comfortably, they have no reason to change further.

That is the whole idea behind **progressive overload**: gradually increasing the demand on your muscles so there is always a new reason to adapt. The American College of Sports Medicine (ACSM) describes progression as necessary if you want your body to keep adapting.¹

“Your body adapts to what you ask of it. Progressive overload means you *never stop asking*.”

More weight is not the only way

Most people hear “progressive overload” and think it means adding plates. Weight is one tool, not the only one. In a 2022 study published in *PeerJ*, trained lifters followed one of two plans for eight weeks. One group added weight and kept their reps the same. The other kept the weight the same and added reps. Both groups gained similar muscle size and strength.²

That finding shapes this workbook. You will progress by adding reps first, then weight, a method called **double progression** (page 6). It works with dumbbells at home, machines at a busy gym or a barbell, and it tells you exactly when to move up.

Effort is the part you cannot skip

Adding reps or weight only works if your sets are hard enough to matter. The 2026 ACSM guidelines note that light and heavy loads both build muscle, as long as each set is taken close to failure. You don’t need to reach failure; stopping a couple of reps short works.³ Stop too early and your log looks good on paper while your muscles barely notice.

So every session in this plan asks two things of you: do a little more than last time, and make each set count. The next pages show you how.

¹ ACSM Position Stand, [Progression Models in Resistance Training](#) (2009) · ² Plotkin et al., [PeerJ](#) (2022) · ³ ACSM Position Stand, [Resistance Training Prescription](#) (2026) · Go deeper: [What is progressive overload?](#)

WHAT CHANGED IN 2026

The new rules of *strength training*

In 2026 the ACSM updated its resistance training guidelines for the first time in 17 years, drawing on 137 systematic reviews and more than 30,000 people. Here is what it means for you.

01

ANY TRAINING BEATS NONE

The biggest jump in results comes from going from no training to regular training. A plan you follow beats a perfect plan you skip.

02

TRAIN EACH MUSCLE TWICE A WEEK

At least two sessions per muscle group each week. This plan's three full-body days train most major muscles three times.

03

10+ WEEKLY SETS FOR GROWTH

For muscle size, aim for at least 10 sets per muscle group per week. This plan works up to about 9–10 for most muscles.

04

YOU DON'T NEED TO HIT FAILURE

Training to absolute failure isn't required. Stopping a few reps short gives similar results with less fatigue.

05

LIGHT OR HEAVY BOTH BUILD MUSCLE

Loads from 30% to 100% of your max all work for growth, as long as each set is taken close to failure.

06

HEAVIER FOR PURE STRENGTH

For maximum strength, the guidelines favour heavier loads (80%+ of your one-rep max) on key lifts done early in the session.

IN THIS WORKBOOK

How this plan follows the 2026 guidelines

- ✓ Three sessions a week, so most muscles are trained 3×
- ✓ About 9–10 weekly sets for most major muscles from week 4
- ✓ Target of 1–3 reps in reserve, never grinding to failure
- ✓ Big compound lifts first, while you are fresh

Source: ACSM Position Stand, [Resistance Training Prescription for Muscle Function, Hypertrophy, and Physical Performance in Healthy Adults](#) (2026) and the [ACSM announcement](#). Summarised for general readers.

THE TOOLKIT

7 ways to progress, *not just weight*

Weight is one lever. Here are seven, with the right moment to pull each one.

- | | | |
|---|--|---|
| 1 | ADD WEIGHT
The classic. Use it once you hit the top of your rep range on every set. | BENCH
30 → 32.5 KG |
| 2 | ADD REPS
Same weight, one more rep. Your default move in this plan. | SQUAT
3×8 → 3×9 |
| 3 | ADD A SET
More total work. This plan adds sets at the start of weeks 4 and 8. | ROW
2 → 3 SETS |
| 4 | SLOW THE LOWERING
A 3-second lowering phase adds time under tension. Useful when you lack heavier weights. | TEMPO
1 S → 3 S DOWN |
| 5 | INCREASE RANGE OF MOTION
Deeper squats, a fuller stretch at the bottom. Build range before you add load. | SQUAT
BOX → FULL DEPTH |
| 6 | HARDER VARIATION
Use it when the smallest weight jump available is too big for you. | PUSH-UP
KNEES → TOES |
| 7 | CUT REST TIME
Same work in less time. Better for fitness than for size, so use it sparingly. | REST
120 S → 90 S |

WHICH LEVER, WHEN?

GYM WITH FULL EQUIPMENT

Use 1 and 2 (reps, then weight). Add 3 at the planned weeks.

HOME, LIMITED WEIGHTS

Use 2, 4, 5 and 6 once your heaviest dumbbells stop being hard.

SHORT ON TIME

Keep sets and reps; use 7 carefully, and never below 60 seconds on big lifts.

Change one thing at a time. If you add weight and cut rest in the same week and the session goes badly, you won't know which change caused it.

Go deeper: [Progressive overload without adding weight](#) · [Time under tension](#)

THE ONE RULE

The double *progression* rule

One rule decides every progression in this plan. Learn it once and use it for years.

THE RULE

Work inside a rep range. When you hit the *top of the range on every set* with good form, add the smallest weight jump you can. Then build the reps back up.



EXAMPLE: DUMBBELL BENCH PRESS, 8-12 REPS

SESSION	WEIGHT	REPS (3 SETS)	NEXT
1	14 kg	9 · 8 · 8	Add reps
2	14 kg	10 · 9 · 8	Add reps
3	14 kg	11 · 10 · 10	Add reps
4	14 kg	12 · 11 · 11	Add reps
5	14 kg	12 · 12 · 12	Add weight ✓
6	16 kg	9 · 8 · 8	Build again

HOW MUCH TO ADD

LIFT TYPE	ADD
Upper body presses, rows	1–2.5 kg or next dumbbell
Lower body squat, RDL	2.5–5 kg
Small muscles curls, raises	Go 2–3 reps past the top first

Research check: the ACSM progression model suggests a 2–10% load increase once you can do 1–2 reps more than your target on two sessions in a row.¹ To play it safe, wait until you hit the top of the range two sessions in a row before adding weight.

3 MISTAKES THAT BREAK THE RULE

✗ COUNTING UGLY REPS

Half-depth squats and bounced presses don't count toward the top of the range.

✗ JUMPING TOO FAR

Add the smallest weight available. Big jumps make reps crash and form slip.

✗ ADDING WEIGHT EVERYWHERE

Each exercise moves on its own schedule. Squats may jump twice before curls jump once.

¹ ACSM Position Stand, *Progression Models in Resistance Training* (2009)

BEFORE YOU START

Find your *starting weight*

No guesswork and no max testing. Use reps in reserve to pick the right weight in your first week.

Reps in reserve (RIR) is how many more clean reps you could have done when you stopped the set. It is the simplest way to measure effort. Research supports it for new and experienced lifters, and your accuracy improves with practice.⁴ Every set in this plan has an RIR target.

0

FAILURE

Couldn't do another rep. Avoid in this plan.

1

NEAR MAX

One rep left. Last sets, weeks 9–12.

2

HARD

Two reps left. Your main target.

3

SOLID

Three reps left. Weeks 1–3 while learning.

4+

TOO EASY

Add weight on the next set.

THE 3-STEP TEST

- 1 Choose a weight you think you could lift about 12 times.
- 2 Do 8 reps, then stop and ask: how many more could I do with clean form?
- 3 Adjust with the table, then write the weight in your log.

REPS LEFT AFTER 8	WHAT TO DO
5 or more	Too light. Add 10–20% next set.
3–4	Your starting weight for weeks 1–3.
1–2	Good for later. For week 1, drop 5–10%.
0 / form broke	Too heavy. Drop 15–20%.

ALREADY KNOW A REP MAX?

Estimate your one-rep max with the Brzycki formula:

$$1RM = \text{weight} \div (1.0278 - 0.0278 \times \text{reps})$$

Start this plan at about 60–65% of that number.

CALIBRATE ONCE A WEEK

New lifters often stop sets further from failure than they think. Once a week, take the last set of one exercise to 1 RIR to check what “hard” feels like.

YOUR FIRST SESSION CHECKLIST

- ☐ Log pages printed (p.15)
- ☐ 5-minute warm-up done
- ☐ Pen or phone for notes
- ☐ Starting weight found for each lift

⁴ Zourdos et al., *J Strength Cond Res* (2016) · Go deeper: [RPE vs RIR explained](#) · [How to calculate your 1RM](#)

THE BIG PICTURE

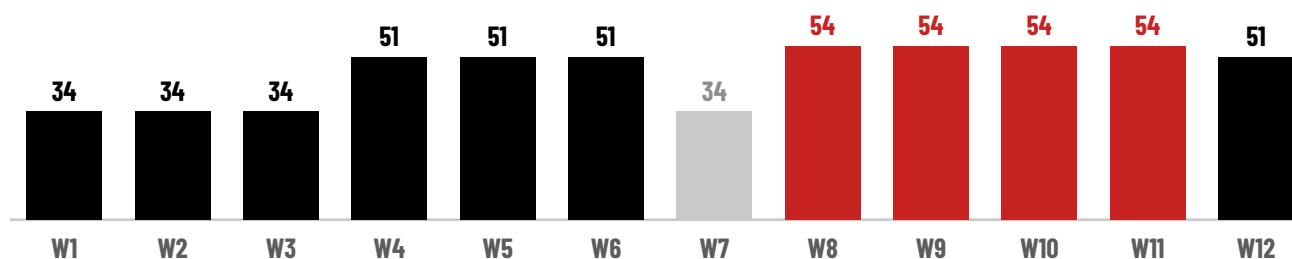
Your 12-week map

Four phases, one direction. Each phase asks a little more, and one lighter week keeps you fresh.

WEEKS 1–3	LEARN 2 SETS • 3 RIR Learn the lifts, find your weights and log every set. Add a rep wherever form allows.
WEEKS 4–6	BUILD 3 SETS • 2 RIR Add the third set. Run double progression on every exercise; expect your first weight jumps.
WEEK 7	DELOAD 2 SETS • 4 RIR Same weights, fewer sets, easier effort. Fatigue clears so you start week 8 fresh.
WEEKS 8–11	PUSH 3–4 SETS • 1–2 RIR Four sets on the first exercise of each day. From week 9, take the last set of each exercise to 1 RIR.
WEEK 12	TEST 3 SETS • 1–2 RIR Record your best set on every main lift and compare it with week 1.

TOTAL WORKING SETS PER WEEK

Volume builds, dips at week 7, then builds again



YOUR WEEK

MON A	TUE WALK	WED B	THU REST	FRI C	SAT ACTIVE	SUN REST
------------------------	---------------------------	------------------------	---------------------------	------------------------	-----------------------------	---------------------------

Why sets go up in weeks 4 and 8: more weekly sets means more growth, up to a point.⁵ Adding them in steps lets your recovery keep up.

Can't train Mon–Wed–Fri? Any three days work. Just leave at least one rest day between sessions.

⁵ Schoenfeld et al., *J Sports Sci* (2017) • Go deeper: [What is a deload week?](#)

THREE FULL-BODY DAYS

The *workouts*

Sets per exercise: 2 (weeks 1–3) · 3 (weeks 4–6) · 2 (week 7) · 3, with 4 on exercise 1 (weeks 8–11) · 3 (week 12)

Warm up every session: 5 minutes of light cardio, then 2 lighter sets of your first exercise. About 45–60 minutes per session in total.

A SQUAT & PUSH Monday

EXERCISE	REPS	REST	HOME SWAP
1 Goblet or back squat	8–12	2 min	Goblet squat, heavy dumbbell
2 Dumbbell bench press	8–12	90 s	Floor press or push-up
3 One-arm dumbbell row	10–15	90 s	Same
4 Lateral raise	12–20	60 s	Same, or band raise
5 Plank	30–60 s	60 s	Same (add 10 s to progress)

B HINGE & PULL Wednesday

EXERCISE	REPS	REST	HOME SWAP
1 Romanian deadlift	8–12	2 min	Dumbbell RDL
2 Overhead press	8–12	90 s	Seated dumbbell press
3 Lat pulldown	10–15	90 s	Band pulldown or chin-up negatives
4 Split squat each leg	10–15	90 s	Same, holding dumbbells
5 Push-up	Stop at 2 RIR	60 s	Same (knees if needed)
6 Dead bug each side	8–12	60 s	Same

C LEGS & UPPER Friday

EXERCISE	REPS	REST	HOME SWAP
1 Leg press	10–15	2 min	Dumbbell step-up
2 Incline dumbbell press	8–12	90 s	Feet-elevated push-up
3 Seated cable row	10–15	90 s	Chest-supported dumbbell row
4 Hip thrust	8–12	90 s	Dumbbell glute bridge
5 Dumbbell curl	10–15	60 s	Same
6 Triceps pushdown	10–15	60 s	Overhead dumbbell extension

Go deeper: [Warm-up sets vs working sets](#) · [How many sets per muscle group per week?](#)

TICK IT OFF

Week-by-week *targets*

One focus per week. Tick a box after each session and watch 36 boxes fill up.

WK	PHASE	SETS	RIR	THIS WEEK'S FOCUS	A B C
1	Learn	2	3	Find starting weights (p.07). Log every set.	☐ ☐ ☐
2	Learn	2	3	Add 1 rep per set wherever form allows.	☐ ☐ ☐
3	Learn	2	3	Film one set of squats and RDLs to check form.	☐ ☐ ☐
4	Build	3	2	Add the third set. Weights can stay the same.	☐ ☐ ☐
5	Build	3	2	First weight jumps on lifts at the top of their range.	☐ ☐ ☐
6	Build	3	2	Fill in the week 6 checkpoint below.	☐ ☐ ☐
7	Deload	2	4	Same weights, fewer sets. Aim for 8 hours of sleep.	☐ ☐ ☐
8	Push	3-4	2	4 sets on the first exercise of each day.	☐ ☐ ☐
9	Push	3-4	1-2	Last set of each exercise at 1 RIR.	☐ ☐ ☐
10	Push	3-4	1-2	Lift stuck? Use the Plateau Fixer (p.14).	☐ ☐ ☐
11	Push	3-4	1-2	Last hard week. Note your best sets.	☐ ☐ ☐
12	Test	3	1-2	Record best sets. Compare with week 1 (p.16).	☐ ☐ ☐

Missed a session? Don't double up. Do the next workout in the order A → B → C and carry on. One missed day changes nothing; a missed month does.

Bad day? If every lift feels heavy, match last week's numbers instead of beating them. Holding steady on a bad day still counts.

CHECKPOINT: END OF WEEK 6

SESSIONS DONE ___ / 18

LIFTS THAT MOVED UP IN WEIGHT

CHECKPOINT: END OF WEEK 12

SESSIONS DONE ___ / 36

BIGGEST JUMP SINCE WEEK 1

CONVERSATION

SADIA BALOCH: SMALL WINS, EVERY WEEK

EM

By ExerciseMenu Editorial
Interview with our head coach

Starting is the easy part. Knowing what to do in week five, week eight and week twelve is harder. We asked our head coach how she takes a new client from their first week to their twelfth, and what she changes when progress slows.

Q: WHEN A NEW CLIENT STARTS, WHAT DO YOU LOOK AT FIRST?

A: Their habits, not their strength. I want to know how many days a week they can train without the rest of their life falling apart. After that, I watch them move: a squat, a push-up, a row. That tells me where to start far better than any test.

Q: WHAT DOES THE FIRST MONTH LOOK LIKE?

A: Boring, on purpose. We keep the weights manageable, the reps controlled, and I ask them to write everything down. The goal for month one is to own the movements. People are surprised how quickly they get stronger just by learning

the lifts properly. A lot of that early progress is the nervous system getting better at the skill.

Q: HOW DO YOU DECIDE WHEN A CLIENT SHOULD ADD WEIGHT?

A: When they hit the top of their rep range on every set and the last rep looks like the first. That's the double progression rule in this workbook. I never add weight because a client feels good on one day. It has to show up in the log, not only in how they feel.

Q: WHAT'S THE BIGGEST MISTAKE YOU SEE IN THE FIRST 12 WEEKS?

A: Adding weight too fast. Someone has a great week, jumps five kilos, their form falls apart and they stall or get hurt. Small jumps, often, win every time.

“Three sessions they show up for *beat five sessions they skip.*”

Q: WHAT DO YOU CHANGE FIRST WHEN A CLIENT STOPS PROGRESSING?

A: I check sleep and food before I touch the program. Most stalls I see are recovery problems in disguise. If recovery is fine, I look at effort: are they stopping sets too early? Only then do I change the exercises or the rep range.

Q: WHY IS THERE A LIGHTER WEEK IN THE MIDDLE OF THE PLAN?

A: Fatigue builds quietly. By week six most people are carrying more of it than they realise. One easier week lets it clear, and clients often come back in week eight stronger than they left week six.

Q: WHAT DOES A SUCCESSFUL 12 WEEKS LOOK LIKE?

A: Thirty-six sessions logged, or close to it. Better form. Weights that were hard in week one feel manageable. The numbers matter, but consistency is the real result, because it carries into the next twelve weeks.

Q: ONE PIECE OF ADVICE FOR SOMEONE STARTING TODAY?

A: Write it down. Every set, every session. Your log is your coach when I'm not there. When you feel stuck, open it and look at week one.

THE COACH'S 3 RULES

- 1 Add reps before you add weight.
- 2 Fix recovery before you change the program.
- 3 If it isn't written down, it didn't happen.

“

I'd rather a client add one rep a week for twelve weeks than add a big weight once and spend a month stuck.

SB**HEAD COACH**

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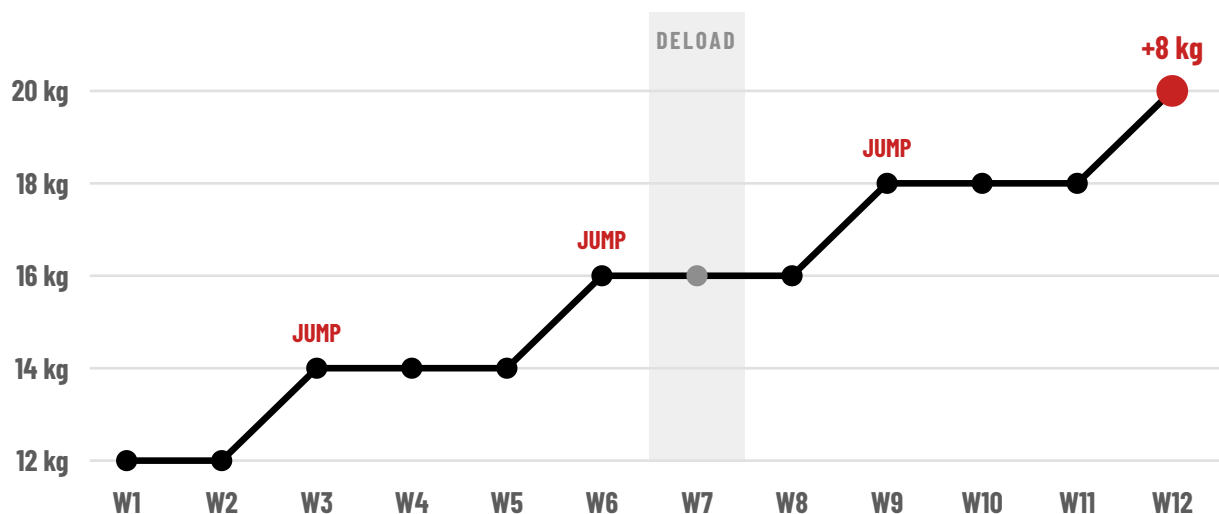
ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLE

12 weeks *on paper*

How one lift can move through this plan. Your numbers will differ, but the pattern is what matters.

DUMBBELL BENCH PRESS: WEIGHT PER HAND

Example trainee, 8–12 rep range



01

FLAT WEEKS ARE PROGRESS

The weight often stays the same for 2–3 weeks while reps climb. The flat parts of the line are where the next jump is built.

02

A DELOAD IS NOT A STEP BACK

In week 7 the sets drop but the weight holds. On the chart the line stays flat. It doesn't go down.

03

SMALL LIFTS MOVE SLOWER

Squats and presses jump every 1–3 weeks early on. Raises and curls may take far longer. That is normal.

Your turn: write your week 1 and week 12 best sets on the Progress Tracker (p.16). Comparing the two is the most motivating page in this workbook.

This is an illustrative example built from the plan's rules, not data from a real client.

WHEN THINGS STALL

Stuck? The *plateau fixer*

Find what you're seeing in the left column. Check the cause, then try the fix for two weeks.

IF THIS HAPPENS	CHECK THIS	TRY THIS
Same reps for 2+ weeks on one lift	Effort: are sets ending at 3+ RIR?	Take the last set to 1 RIR for two sessions.
Reps dropping on most lifts	Sleep and recovery	Aim for 7–9 hours; take the deload a week early.
Can't reach the range after a weight jump	The jump was too big	Go back down; use rep or tempo progress to bridge.
Form breaks on the last reps	Load too heavy	Drop 5–10% and lower the weight over 3 seconds.
Joint pain (not muscle soreness)	Exercise choice	Swap to a pain-free variation. See a professional if it persists.
Skiping sessions	Schedule and motivation	Keep the plan; swap one accessory lift for a similar one you enjoy.

RECOVERY ESSENTIALS

7–9h

SLEEP

Sleep is when much of your recovery happens. Short sleep over several nights shows up as weaker sessions. [Sleep & muscle growth](#)

1.6 g

PROTEIN PER KG

A meta-analysis of 49 studies found gains levelled off around 1.6 g of protein per kg of body weight per day.⁶ At 70 kg, that's about 112 g a day.

48h

REST BETWEEN

Leave a day between sessions. Walks and light movement on off days count as active recovery. [Rest vs active recovery](#)

⁶ Morton et al., *Br J Sports Med* (2018)

Weekly *training log*

Write reps in each set box.
Circle the lift you'll add weight to next time.

WEEK	DATES	PHASE				TARGET RIR	
EXERCISE	KG	SET 1	SET 2	SET 3	SET 4	RIR	NEXT TIME
WORKOUT A • SQUAT & PUSH							
Squat							
DB bench press							
One-arm row							
Lateral raise							
Plank (sec)							
WORKOUT B • HINGE & PULL							
Romanian deadlift							
Overhead press							
Lat pulldown							
Split squat							
Push-up							
Dead bug							
WORKOUT C • LEGS & UPPER							
Leg press							
Incline DB press							
Seated cable row							
Hip thrust							
DB curl							
Triceps pushdown							
AVG SLEEP (H)		ENERGY 1-5			BEST SET THIS WEEK		

12-week *progress tracker*

Each week, write your best set for each main lift as **kg × reps** (e.g. 16×10).

LIFT	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12
Squat												
DB bench												
Row												
RDL												
Overhead press												
Pulldown												
Hip thrust												

SESSIONS COMPLETED: TICK ONE PER WORKOUT

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15	16	17	18	19	20
21	22	23	24	25	26	27	28	29	30	31	32	33	34	35	36				

BODY CHECK (optional)

MEASURE	WEEK 1	WEEK 6	WEEK 12
Body weight			
Waist (cm)			
Progress photo taken			

WEEK 1 VS WEEK 12

BIGGEST IMPROVEMENT

LIFT THAT FELT EASIEST BY THE END

HOW MY CLOTHES FIT / HOW I FEEL

NEXT 12 WEEKS

MY GOAL

TWO EXERCISES TO SWAP

START DATE

YOU ASKED

Quick *answers*

Can I do this plan at home with only dumbbells?

Yes. Every exercise has a home swap on page 9. When your heaviest dumbbells get easy, use slower lowering, pauses or one-arm and one-leg versions.

Should I feel sore after every session?

No. Soreness is common in the first weeks and after new exercises, but it doesn't measure progress. Your log does.

What do I do after week 12?

Run the plan again starting from your week 12 weights, and swap two or three exercises for close variations to keep it fresh.

The next dumbbell is too heavy. What now?

Stay at your current weight and go 2–3 reps past the top of the range, or slow the lowering to 3 seconds. Move up once you reach 15 clean reps.

Can I add cardio?

Yes. Do hard cardio after lifting or on non-lifting days, and keep easy walks on rest days. [Cardio before or after weights?](#)

I'm over 50. Is this plan for me?

The structure suits most healthy adults. Start at 3–4 RIR and progress reps before weight. [Reps and sets over 50](#)

SOURCES

- 1 American College of Sports Medicine. Progression models in resistance training for healthy adults. *Med Sci Sports Exerc.* 2009;41(3):687–708. pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/19204579
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Please note: this workbook is general information, not medical advice. If you have an injury or a medical condition, or you are returning to exercise after a long break, check with your doctor before starting.

KEEP GOING

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01

HOW MANY SETS PER MUSCLE GROUP PER WEEK?

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02

HYPERTROPHY VS STRENGTH: WHICH TO PICK

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03

DROP SETS VS SUPERSETS VS PYRAMID SETS

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04

RPE VS RIR: HOW HARD SHOULD A SET FEEL?

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